



March 10, 2025

To: White House Office of Science and Technology Policy; Networking and Information Technology Research and Development (NITRD) National Coordination Office (NCO), National Science Foundation

Re: University of Illinois Chicago Response to the Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence Action Plan

A. Introduction

The University of Illinois Chicago (UIC) is a public research university that provides education to more than 34,000 students, advances discovery through a rough \$500 million research portfolio, and engages deeply in the communities that compose our home city, the third most populous city in the United States. Its mission is to “provide the broadest access to the highest levels of educational, research, and clinical excellence”¹, and, through the application and dissemination of that excellence, to transform the world. We understand artificial intelligence to be a powerful tool in helping us achieve that mission. President Trump’s desire to use the United States’ preeminence in artificial intelligence to further human flourishing, economic competitiveness, and national security, as expressed in Executive Order 14179 of January 23, 2025 (“Removing Barriers to American Leadership in Artificial Intelligence”), resonates strongly with our mission. Accordingly, UIC is honored to respond to the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy’s Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence Action Plan.

¹ For more details on UIC’s mission, see <https://chancellor.uic.edu/about/mission/> (last visited 03.10.2025).

B. Presuppositions about the United States AI Policy as expressed in EO 14179

Section 2 of Executive Order 14179 expresses the US AI policy as follows:

It is the policy of the United States to sustain and enhance America's global AI dominance in order to promote human flourishing, economic competitiveness, and national security.

Based on commonsense and the best available research², this responsive memorandum understands “human flourishing” as a state of optimal well-being and functioning, characterized by the ability to thrive across multiple dimensions of life, inclusive of physical, mental, and social aspects. It involves:

1. Having a clear sense of purpose and direction in life;
2. Continuously developing and realizing one's potential;
3. Effectively adapting to challenges and adversities;
4. Building and maintaining meaningful and supportive relationships;
5. Actively participating in and contributing to the well-being of the community; and
6. Maintaining good health and general well-being.

We understand “economic competitiveness” to mean both domestic robustness in the marketplace overall, and, more importantly in the context of AI, increased capacity to compete with foreign allies and adversaries on a global scale. In our estimation, “National security” concerns the safeguarding of the U.S. and the protection of its citizens – both physically and digitally.

C. Highest Priority Items to be Included in the U.S.’s AI Action Plan

Given the instructions of the Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence Action Plan, and our estimation of what Americans need in order to flourish; our sense of the fundamental requirements for increased U.S. economic competitiveness in this Age of AI; and our vision of a more robust national security commensurate with the complexities of the 21st century, we offer the following five policy recommendations:

² See, for example, the work of The Forum on Human Flourishing in a Digital Age at <https://philosophy.illinois.edu/academics/illinois-forum-human-flourishing-digital-age> (last visited 03.10.2025).

1. EDUCATION AND WORKFORCE DEVELOPMENT:

a. **Expand AI Education Programs: Increase funding and support for AI-related educational programs at all levels, from K-12 to higher education.** This action aligns with the Administration's priority of human flourishing.

b. **Lifelong Learning Initiatives: Promote policies that support lifelong learning and continuous professional development in AI and related fields.** This will empower individuals to stay current with technological advancements and enhance their career prospects, both of which are essential for economic competitiveness.

2. RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT:

a. **Invest in Research Infrastructure: Increase investments in research infrastructure to position academic institutions and industry partners at the forefront of AI knowledge and discovery.** Advancing research capabilities is valuable but requires significant investment. It will pay off, but on unpredictable timetables. It cannot be left to private actors operating with strictly short-term ROI calculations.

b. **Interdisciplinary Research: Promote interdisciplinary research collaborations that address complex societal changes brought about or exacerbated by AI innovations.** The societal implications of AI are likely to be profound.³ Human flourishing, economic competitiveness, and national security could be de-railed, potentially even terminally, if we do not actively and chronically anticipate challenges and problems.

3. PARTNERSHIPS AND INNOVATION:

a. **Public-Private Partnerships: Spur new and intensify existing partnerships between academic institutions, businesses, and nonprofits to enhance innovation, technology transfer and**

³ For vivid descriptions of the societal implications of machine learning, see Kissinger, H. A., Schmidt, E., & Huttenlocher, D. (2021). *The Age of AI: And Our Human Future*. Hachette UK, 16-27.

employment prospects. Similarly to 2. (a) and (b) *supra*, valuable synergies that would not otherwise occur will become eventualities as a result of such encouragement.

4. DATA PRIVACY AND SECURITY:

a. **Robust Data Governance: Mandate or, at minimum, encourage strong data privacy and security measures throughout the AI system lifecycle to protect against data breaches and AI model attacks.** This will help ensure the ethical and secure use of AI systems and encourage Americans' comfort with AI. In the absence of citizen-users feeling secure with AI applications, it is unlikely that the Administration's AI aspirations can be realized.

b. **Transparency and Explainability: Promote the development of AI systems with transparent and explainable outputs, enhancing trust and accountability in AI applications.** The rationale here is the same as that of 4. (a) *supra*.

5. NATIONAL SECURITY AND DEFENSE:

a. **Ethical AI in Defense: Encourage the development of and commitment to ethical guidelines for AI applications in national security and defense to ensure responsible and humane applications.** Domestic investigations, intelligence and military use of AI will likely continue to be domains of high sensitivity for many Americans. Broad public support will be undermined, perhaps irreparably, if AI is used unethically to further domestic surveillance or other military actions.

UIC appreciates the opportunity to respond to the Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence Action Plan. Per requirements of the RFI, "This document is approved for public dissemination. The document contains no business-proprietary or confidential information. Document contents may be reused by the government in developing the AI Action Plan and associated documents without attribution." If questions arise, or more information is needed, contact University of Illinois Chicago Associate Vice Chancellor for Data Science and Artificial Intelligence Strategy Michael G Bennett at [REDACTED]

Respectfully submitted,



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